

defy the odds and last a lifetime. But several years into the relationship, Janice began an affair with a colleague while on a business trip. She didn't expect it to last, so she kept it from her husband, thinking it would run its course and fade away. Through a trail of hotel and restaurant receipts (it always comes back to money), Ian discovered the deceit. Rage and jealousy sent him straight to a lawyer rather than seeking counseling or mediation. He immediately fought for full custody of the two boys and the family home. What could have been prevented through counseling or lessened through mediation turned into a full-blown divorce case that dragged its way through court for two years. In the end, a three-month dalliance and a measure of deceit cost the couple \$126,000, their entire net worth. Here's the kicker: This couple got back together a few years later. You could call that a happy ending to a sad story, or just a very expensive chapter.

Money Mistake: Divorce Is Killing Your Bottom Line

THE FIX: DON'T LET YOUR MONEY BE THE THIRD CASUALTY IN THE SPLIT

You tried. You really tried. But in the end, divorce remains the last option available to you after a few months of counseling and a cooling-off period during which you lived separate lives in different places. At the end of the day, you still feel divorce is the best way forward, even if your partner doesn't quite agree. This is a common scenario: One wants out of the marriage a little or a lot more than the other. It's not uncontested, it won't necessarily be fully amicable, and yet both partners want to avoid the hell and high cost of going to court.

How do you proceed?

With caution, respect, and whatever amount of love you can still conjure from the early days you were together. It's hard to believe, but the person you're pulling away from was once the love of your life, and if you can exercise a bit of compassion, it'll go a long way toward